at Persepolis in modern Iran''.[17] More discoveries may yet happen—much of ancient Pataliputra lies unexcavated beneath modern Patna.)

The land is fertile and enables two harvests a year, writes Megasthenes. Fruit trees abound and rivers are aplenty. Thanks to the 'abundant means of subsistence', people exceed 'ordinary stature', possess a 'proud bearing', and are 'well skilled in the arts'. They hold truth and virtue in high esteem, and 'accord no special privileges to the old unless they possess superior wisdom'.

The people of this kingdom are called Prasii (likely a Greek rendition of the Sanskrit *prācya*, or 'east'[18]). They 'observe good order' and live 'happily enough, being simple in their manners and frugal'. That said, they also 'love finery and ornament. Their robes are worked in gold, and ornamented with precious stones, and they also wear flowered garments made of the finest muslin'. 'Attendants walking behind hold up umbrellas over them: for they have a high regard for beauty, and avail themselves of every device to improve their looks.'

This wasn't just a penchant of the Prasii. Even the wealthy folk of Punjab, wrote Nearchus, 'wear earrings of ivory' and 'use parasols as a screen from the heat'. They wear elaborately trimmed shoes of white leather, with multicoloured soles 'of great thickness, to make the wearer seem so much taller'. Others dye their beards 'according to taste'. 'Some dye their white beards to make them look as white as possible, but others dye them blue; while some again prefer a red tint, some a purple, and others a rank green.'[19]

Elite Prasii men 'marry many wives, whom they buy from their parents, giving in exchange a yoke of oxen'. 'Some they marry hoping to find in them willing helpmates; and others for pleasure and to fill their houses with children.' Megasthenes writes, 'The wives prostitute themselves unless they are compelled to be chaste'; but he offers no explanation for this puzzling remark. The king is cared for by 'women, who are also bought from their parents'. The king leaves his palace not only in times of war but also to judge cases in court, to offer sacrifices and to go hunting, which he does with great fanfare and is accompanied by two or three women hunters by his side. The 'king has in his pay a standing army of 600,000 foot soldiers,